



Painted snail, Eastern Cuba



A garden snail would take around three minutes to slide across these pages. This mollusc has to carry its home with it on its back – a spiralling shell that it can hide inside if danger approaches. The world's largest snail shell belongs to the huge African land snail, which is the size of a guinea pig, but some of the most colourful shells belong to the painted snail.

Snails travel on a single squishy “foot”, which is actually a massive muscle. The snail ripples the muscle to push itself along. About a third of a snail's energy goes into making slime, which helps it glide smoothly along, leaving a silvery trail wherever it goes.